

W5 Values, Heuristics & Bias

WHAT THIS FRAME MEANS

This frame asks you to look beneath the surface of an argument and ask: What assumption is driving this? What value is being prioritized? What is being left out or distorted? People often disagree not because they have different facts, but because they start from different values or unconscious assumptions. This frame helps you name those differences.

WHAT TO TRY

- Identify the stated reason for a policy or position
- Name the underlying value or assumption behind it
- Show how a different value or assumption would lead to a different conclusion
- Identify what the argument leaves out or distorts

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "The stated rationale is..., but the underlying assumption is..."
- "This argument prioritizes... over..."
- "Those who disagree are not wrong about the facts — they weight the values differently."
- "The bias here is that..."
- "What this argument does not account for is..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

"The argument for limiting legacy admissions assumes that university admissions should be merit-based. But the unstated assumption is that existing merit criteria — test scores and grades — are themselves neutral measures of ability. Critics argue that those criteria already reflect socioeconomic advantage, so removing legacy preferences without addressing the underlying measurement system may produce less change than expected."